



**JAMAICA CONSTABULARY FORCE**  
Briefing and Debriefing Guidelines

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| <b>Authors: ACP Operations Branch</b>                | <b>Owner: JCF</b>                                             |
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## Briefing and De-Briefing



**A**n essential component of all successful police operations is an effective “Briefing” before an Operation and a thorough “Debriefing” upon conclusion.

### 1.0 BRIEFING

1. Briefing is the process of providing, receiving and understanding information. The manner in which this is done however is the key to whether the Briefing is effective and achieves all of the desired objectives (results).
2. To deliver an effective Briefing requires the careful management of time, preparation, planning, knowledge of your subject, confidence, an awareness of your audience and an appreciation that you regularly need to test understanding and information retention. This can be achieved by either - providing a written Briefing Note supporting the verbal Briefing, or by requiring the recipient to take a written note of what is being said. To test understanding you ask relevant questions in a supportive, helpful manner.
3. The ability to be able to “Brief” effectively is a key leadership skill and requires regular practice whereby you develop your public speaking skills and gain confidence. The old adage “Practice makes perfect” is certainly appropriate with regard to being able to “Brief” effectively.
4. The purpose of a “briefing” is to impart information/knowledge, in other words to enable the participants to “learn”. It is therefore important to create a suitable environment/atmosphere whereby people can maximize their learning. This is particularly important when Briefing for Police Operations where the “risk assessment” indicates a high level of risk to the personal safety of the public and specifically to the police officers involved.

5. The first step therefore is to use the most suitable facility available, ensure that all participants can be accommodated and make them as comfortable as possible in order that they are receptive to receiving, understanding and retaining essential information.
6. It is good practice to regularly emphasize the need for the full attention of all participants at “Briefings” to receive information that is likely to affect their personal safety and the safety of the public.

It is good practice for Police Briefings to be in TWO parts:

### **1.1 The formal parade/inspection**

*All staff members are to be accounted for, deployments made and personal appointments equipment checked by the Supervisor. This is a sound discipline that establishes and reinforces the standards of the organization and encourages personal responsibility and self-discipline*

**In all major police operations the actual Briefing should follow the structured IRIMAC format, namely:**

| <b>IRIMAC</b>              |                                                       |
|----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>I - Information</b>     | Relevant facts of the Operation                       |
| <b>R - Risk Assessment</b> | Identifying the risks for <u>Appropriate Response</u> |
| <b>I - Intention</b>       | Purpose, objectives of operation                      |
| <b>M - Method</b>          | The Plan, how the purpose will be achieved            |
| <b>A - Administration</b>  | Support, equipment, welfare, de-briefing etc.,        |
| <b>C - Communication</b>   | Personal Radios, R/T Channels, etc.,                  |

## **2.0 THE IMPORTANCE OF RISK MANAGEMENT**

Risk is defined as: “Chance of hazard or of bad consequences” or exposure to mischance” or” expose to chance of injury or loss”. Assessment” is defined as: “fix amount of” or “estimate

Risk Assessment is critical to police operations in order to mitigate against danger, injuries and damage to the police and the community. The objective in conducting a risk assessment in relation to all Police Operations is to identify all those factors that are potential hazards / bad consequences and to take action to remove them or at the very least reduces their effect / impact.

The concept of risk assessment is not new in modern policing. It is now a tried and tested standard procedure in strategic planning and in conducting many types of police operations, including spontaneous incidents such as Hostage / Siege / Terrorist situations and operations such as marches and public demonstrations. It is extensively used for pre-planned and spontaneous firearms operations.

Clearly, in pre-planned operations there is more time to conduct an in-depth, informed “risk assessment” whereas with spontaneous incidents time is limited. However, experience has shown that failure to conduct any “risk assessment” irrespective of the circumstances of the police operation can have disastrous results. Essential to conducting a risk assessment is the provision of as much reliable and up-to-date information as possible. The more accurate the information obtained the more thorough and reliable will be the “risk assessment” prepared.

To illustrate how to conduct a risk assessment in an operational policing context I will give the example of a Missing Persons Report of a young child. Many children are reported missing, but the vast majority return home safely of their own accord within a few hours. However, when reported missing to police, information on all the surrounding circumstances obtained from the informant and its assessment is vital in deciding whether the case is going to be treated as a High Risk, Medium Risk or Low Risk right from the outset.

The quality of information obtained together with its assessment will decide the police actions to be taken if the child is going to be found safe and well. All experience shows that police action taken immediately on receiving a Missing child Report is crucial in finding the child alive. In the case of a Missing Child the following factors will need to be carefully considered in assessing the level of Risk:

Age, suffering any known illness (need for regular medication), physical disability, psychological disorder that may increase risk of harm to him or herself or others, family circumstances, possible child abuse within the family, school problems / bullying. Single parent family — any conflict between natural I substitute parents, involved in any traumatic incident immediately prior to being missing.

Disappearance out of character - never occurred before, result of home search, Suspicious circumstances — evidence of major crime or where crime is suspected, e.g. abduction, kidnap, extortion, etc., any natural dangers of location where last seen, e.g. rivers, undergrowth, busy main highway, weather conditions , where exposure would seriously increase risk to health and safety of child, etc.,

When planning for a Firearms Operation a risk assessment is vital to minimize the risk to members of the public who are likely to be vulnerable and to the police officers participating in the operation.

Public and officer safety issues should always be major considerations in all Risk Assessments.

## **2.1 In the case of a police firearms operation the following should be carefully considered when assessing the level of risk:**

- Suspects, their families and associates (Criminal record, particularly any history of violence).

- Hostages
- Possibility of active support for suspects from other criminals.
- Premises involved - containment, access, exits I escape routes.
- Facilities available to suspects — food and drink (including alcohol), washing and toilet facilities, access to radio, T.V., telephones.
- Description of likely weapons available to suspects.
- Level of tactical armed police response available.
- Availability of specialist resources - skilled and trained police incident commanders, trained negotiators, specialist equipment, body armour, video tape)
- Children / vulnerable people involved (either criminals or hostages).
- Level of public support.
- International and political implications. Media interest - observation points, protective cover
- Public demonstrations and marches are other aspects of police duty that require ongoing risk assessment.

Demonstrations (particularly when spontaneous) have the potential for serious public disorder and loss of life and therefore, need to be dealt with quickly and with sensitivity. The initial and ongoing assessment of the situation is absolutely crucial to employing the appropriate policing strategy and tactics. Such situations change rapidly and the police need to be able to respond quickly to these changes so that tension may be reduced and order maintained.

Dealing with public disorder and demonstrations requires effective “command and control” systems and “contingency plans” that include “rapid mobilization of support units.” A “risk assessment” will enable the Police Incident Commander to deploy resources more appropriately and effectively to restore order and to prevent escalation.

In the case of a spontaneous public demonstration with the potential for serious disorder the following factors will need to be considered in assessing the level of risk and determining the appropriate police response:

## **2.2 Common Hazards at Major Incidents:**

(1) Lethal and other weapons, petrol bombs, other missile attack (2) violent persons — numbers involved, how dressed to prevent identification (3) What tactics are being used by demonstrators /rioters. (4) Tear gas — chemicals or other noxious substances used against the police (5) Paint or other substances thrown at police to obscure vision (6) fumes / smoke inhalation, poor visibility (7) unsafe buildings and other structures (8) elevated protest (9) Traffic hazards (10) Downed electrical wires, broken water hydrants, fire, explosion, noise, etc.

**Identify ringleaders and NEGOTIATE** — seek and facilitate peaceful resolution between parties, consider small deputations.

**Police Personnel** — Injuries, heat, stress or fatigue, dehydration; specific dangers for officers attending in plain clothes and not clearly identifiable as police officers; safety and security of police firearms.

**Safety of police vehicles and equipment**, recovery and treatment of injured police officers, age and experience of police officers involved, need for mature and experienced supervisors to attend scene in first instance. N.B. Initial police response is very crucial in reducing tension and preventing escalation.

Location — Proximity to learning institutions<sup>1</sup> hospitals, residential areas, industrial premises with hazardous material, bridges, tunnels, main highways and other potential hazardous locations.

Political implications local and international (instability) impact on industrial relations, implications for overall social unrest, media interest and response **(N.B. Media can be very powerful in influencing public opinion!)**

**When conducting a “Risk Assessment” consider:**

- Police and community concerns Physical risks
- Psychological risks Political risks Legal risks Economic risks
- Environmental risks Moral risks
- De-information risk

### **Police and Community Concerns**

- Do the police possess the necessary resources, experience and expertise necessary to deal effectively with such a situation?
- Do the other emergency services have the necessary resources, experience and expertise to respond effectively?
- Do all the emergency services have a history of rapid mobilization, close liaison and effective working together at major incidents?
- Is there confidence in the “intelligence services” providing accurate information on the extent and nature of the terrorist threat?
- Is there confidence that the national Government has the will to robustly and consistently combat all forms of terrorism?
- The level of support within your country for the ideals / ambitions of the terrorist organization(s) involved?

### **2.3 Physical Risks**

- The level of risk of death and or injury to personnel responding to the disaster?
- The degree of risk of death and or injury to specialist personnel required to undertake specific tasks. e.g. bomb squad officers (both police and military). The danger of collapsing buildings and damaged services, e.g. gas and electricity?

The danger to all emergency service personnel  conducting rescue and making safe

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if not wearing and using the appropriate equipment?

The availability of the necessary medical equipment and health facilities to deal with such a major emergency with many casualties?

## 2.4 Psychological Risks

The psychological pressures (e.g. post incident trauma) that may be experienced by officers at vulnerable situations?

Are the police officers being used to deal with this major incident sufficiently competent to carry out the tasks required in terms of their knowledge, training and experience?

## 2.5 Political Risks

The internal political pressure to apprehend and successfully convict the perpetrators?

The national and international pressure to take a firm stance against terrorism?

The possible conflicts between ethnic groups with different political, cultural and religious ideologies that become polarized and can bring down governments?

The level of practical Government support and assistance provided to the emergency services to deal effectively with such a situation?

## 2.6 Legal Risks

The issue of senior officers having a ‘Duty of Care’ for their staff to ensure that they are properly equipped and trained for the duties they are likely to perform?

Requirement to comply with and enforce the Law, need to remind/inform officers particularly if new Emergency Legislation is in operation?

- Have police officers the necessary powers/authority to deal with such situations? (i.e. counter-terrorism measures).
- Abuse of police powers and the breach of Human Rights.

## 2.7 Economic Risks

- Dangers to economic survival of local people through loss of industries and business and lack of confidence?
- Loss of international reputation and confidence and lack of foreign investment?
- Damage to or loss of essential services/infrastructure that may be impossible or extremely difficult to repair or replace?

## 2.8 De-information Risks



- The inability of the emergency services to satisfying the insatiable demand of the media for information?
- Dangers of inaccurate and misleading media reporting resulting in public - anxiety, alarm and despondency?

**NB: it is recommended that “Briefing” for daily routine (e.g. for foot and mobile patrols) follow the same structured format (IRIMAC) with information on:**

## **2.9 Local Crime**

- Persons wanted / suspected of Crime / Potentially Dangerous
- Hotspots (location of likely Crime / Disorder) Public Demonstrations
- Repeat Domestic Disputes (particularly if violence is likely)

## **2.10 Traffic Problems**

- Congestion
- Accident black-spots
- Traffic enforcement priorities

## **2.11 Administrative Instructions**

- Force Orders
- Human Rights and Police Use of Force & Firearms Policy
- Anti-Corruption Policy Scenes of Crime

## **2.12 Personnel/Welfare Matters**

## **3.0 DE-BRIEFING**

At the end of a tour of duty at a police station/unit or on completion of a specific police operation, it is important that a “De-brief” takes place of all those officers involved. It is good practice that all De-briefings follow a structured format so that essential information or intelligence is not lost.

**A suggested structured format for De-briefings: (PIICTS)**

### **3.1 Personnel**

- conduct a roll call — check that all personnel are accounted for, record details of absences, take steps to trace missing personnel, note any injuries and arrange welfare support.

### **3.2 Information/ Intelligence**

- Obtain and ensure that it is fed into the intelligence system for analysis and

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use.

***N.B. There will be occasions when information obtained from a De-Brief will need to be immediately communicated to all officers to prevent crime and for public and or officer safety reasons.***

Identify Strengths and Weaknesses in Police Operation - seek realistic suggestions for improvement. Do not seek to apportion blame of any mistakes or omissions.

.N.B. Notes of Evidence must be completed before the De-brief commences to prevent suggestions of collusion /impropriety.

### **3.3 Communication**

Check that Notes of EVIDENCE for any offences have been properly recorded and a record kept of all damaged and lost police property and equipment

**Supervisor / Senior Officer to write appropriate Report.**

### **3.4 Thank Officers, recognize good work. Encourage officers to share their experiences through the De-briefing process in order that everyone may learn**

Developing and effective “Briefing and De- briefing” system in any Police Organization will have enormous benefits for crime prevention/detection, disorder reduction and public / officer safety.

